Md. Obaidullah

Department of Politics, University of Virginia
Charlottesville, Virginia
ycj2yt@virginia.edu | mdobaidullah.com

Education

Ph.D., Foreign Affairs — University of Virginia 2026–present
Expected completion: 2031
Fields: Major: International Relations; Minor: Political Methodology

M.A., Political Science — University of Southern Mississippi 2024–2026
Thesis: Diversionary Repression in Electoral Autocracies: Crisis Onset, Loss-Domain Conditions, and State Escalation
Thesis chair: Joe Weinberg

M.S.S., Public Administration — University of Barishal 2020–2021
B.S.S., Public Administration — University of Barishal 2017–2020

Research Interests

Fields	International Relations; Comparative Politics
Substantive	International security, and conflict; foreign policy; great power competition; authoritarianism and democratic backsliding; migration, refugees, and border politics.
Methods	Causal inference; survey research and experiments; panel-data analysis; process tracing; comparative case studies; mixed methods.

Academic Appointments

2024–2026	**Visiting Scholar**, Department of Development Studies, Daffodil International University, Dhaka, Bangladesh
2024–2026	**Teaching Assistant**, Department of Political Science, University of Southern Mississippi, Hattiesburg, MS
2024	**Lecturer**, Department of Development Studies, Daffodil International University, Dhaka, Bangladesh

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

International Relations and Political Science

[8] **Obaidullah, M.** (2027). The American touch: Evaluating the reach of U.S. soft power in India. *Journal of Countries Studies*, *5*(1), 21–66.

[7] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Begum, R. (2026). Regime collapse without civil war: Explaining Bangladesh's July 2024 uprising. *Asian Journal of Comparative Politics*. Advance online publication.

[6] **Obaidullah, M.** (2026). Machiavellian and Hobbesian foundations of democratic decline in Bangladesh. *Contemporary South Asia*, *34*(3), 554–579.

[5] **Obaidullah, M.** (2026). Delivering attraction? How BRI implementation shapes China's soft power in Bangladesh and Pakistan. *China Report*, *62*(2), 257–277.

[4] **Obaidullah, M.** (2026). Choosing not to choose: Qatar's hedging in the U.S.–China rivalry. *Journal of Countries Studies*, *4*(2), 335–371.

[3] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Howlader, M. R. (2025). Assessing geopolitical and socio-economic consequences of India–Bangladesh water disputes. *Discover Global Society*, *3*(1), Article 1.

[2] Sohel, M. S., Sifullah, M. K., Zaman, N. T., Hossain, B., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). Beyond borders: Mapping out the difficulties, stress, and coping strategies in transnational irregular (illegal) labor migration from Bangladesh. *International Journal of Community Well-Being*, *8*(2), 331–357.

[1] **Obaidullah, M.**, Hossain, M., Raihan, M. S., & Hossen, M. S. (2024). From humanitarian crisis to burden: Understanding the Rohingya refugee crisis in Bangladesh. *SN Social Sciences*, *4*(8), Article 141.

Public Health and Development

[6] Sifullah, M. K., Sohel, M. S., Jamil, S., Ahmad, B., Hossain, M. A., **Obaidullah, M.**, Zaman, N. T., Faruk, O., Islam, M. T., & Ali, N. (2025). WASH service accessibility and satisfaction among street informal workers in Dhaka City: A cross-sectional study. *Discover Social Science and Health*, *5*(1), Article 45.

[5] Sohel, M. S., Sifullah, M. K., Hossain, B., Sarker, M. F. H., Zaman, N. T., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2024). Exploring risky health behaviors and vulnerability to sexually transmitted diseases among transnational undocumented labor migrants from Bangladesh: A qualitative study. *BMC Public Health*, *24*(1), Article 1261.

[4] Mamy, M. M. B., **Obaidullah, M.**, Zaman, N. T., Saifullah, M. K., Sohel, M. S., Hossen, M., & Horaira, G. A. (2024). Navigating vulnerabilities: The untold story of informal households in Dhaka, Bangladesh during the COVID-19 pandemic. *New Zealand Journal of Asian Studies*, *26*(2), 75–98.

[3] Sohel, M. S., Alam, S., Rahman, M. M., **Obaidullah, M.**, Anam, A. S. M. T., Hossain, B., & Hossain, M. A. (2024). Exploring the multifaceted vulnerabilities of female street child labor in the capital city of Bangladesh. *Heliyon*, *10*(18), Article e37302.

[2] Sohel, M. S., Jamil, S., **Obaidullah, M.**, Hossain, B., Ali, H. M., Hossen, M. S., Uddin, M. S., Ahsan, T., & Eva, N. F. (2024). Healthcare challenges in disaster-prone riverine islands: A study of Sirajgonj, Bangladesh. *International Journal of Community Well-Being*, *7*(3), 491–515.

[1] Sarker, M. F. H., Ahmed, S. F., Kawser, U., Hossen, M. S., **Obaidullah, M.**, Khan, S., Sifullah, M. K., & Sohel, M. S. (2024). Is e-business breaking down barriers for Bangladesh's young female entrepreneurs during the COVID-19 pandemic? A qualitative study. *SN Social Sciences*, *4*(6), Article 107.

Working Papers

Obaidullah, M. and Weinberg, J. (2026). Conditional Repression: Crisis Onset, Loss Domains, and the Turn to Information Control in Electoral Autocracies. Manuscript in preparation.

Obaidullah, M. and Hossain, M. (2025). India's Influence on Authoritarianism in South Asia: The Case of Sheikh Hasina's Bangladesh (2009–2024). Under review.

Obaidullah, M. and Hossain, M. (2025). Rights Without Entry: The Historical Puzzle of Migrant Inclusion Under Restrictive Border Regimes. *Journal of Immigrant and Refugee Studies*. Revise & Resubmit.

Obaidullah, M. and Hossain, M. (2025). Aid as Small-State Survival: Qatar's Foreign Aid Reorientation After the 2017 Blockade. *Journal of Arabian Studies*. Revise & Resubmit.

Obaidullah, M., Hossain, M., and Howlader, M. R. (2025). Theology as Access: India, the Taliban, and Religious Diplomacy without Recognition. *The Review of Faith & International Affairs*. Revise & Resubmit.

Book Chapters

[7] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Hossain, M. (2025). China's soft power strategy in the Middle East and East Asia: A comparative analysis. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–22). Springer.

[6] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Begum, R. (2025). The Rohingya crisis and its effect on Bangladesh–Myanmar bilateral relations: A historical analysis. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–19). Springer.

[5] Hossain, M., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). China's diplomatic approach to the Rohingya crisis: Balancing economic interests and humanitarian concerns. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–24). Springer.

[4] Sohel, M. S., Hossain, M. A., Sarker, M. F. H., Sifullah, M. K., **Obaidullah, M.**, & Ullah, A. A. (2025). Bangladeshi undocumented migration crisis in Europe: Implications of security, human rights, and policy. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–18). Springer.

[3] Sohel, M. S., Sifullah, M. K., Sarker, M. F. H., Hossain, M. A., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). Security questions explained: Irregular migrants to Europe. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–16). Springer.

[2] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Hossain, M. (2024). Major powers' approaches to the Rohingya crisis and their impact on Bangladesh. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–30). Springer.

[1] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Raihan, M. S. (2024). Soft power competition: A comparative analysis of China and the US in South Asia. In M. Zreik (Ed.), *Soft Power and Diplomatic Strategies in Asia and the Middle East* (pp. 197–226). IGI Global.

Book Reviews

[3] Hossain, M., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). Power of bonding and non-Western soft power strategy in Iran: Comparing China and India's engagement. *Contemporary South Asia*, *33*(1), 145–146.

[2] Hossain, M., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). We had the watches. They had the time: A witness account of the war in Afghanistan. *Small Wars & Insurgencies*, *36*(1), 241–243.

[1] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Hossain, M. (2024). Book review: Kudret Bulbul, Md. Nazmul Islam and Md. Sajid Khan (Eds.), *Rohingya Refugee Crisis in Myanmar: Ethnic Conflict and Resolution*. *Society and Culture in South Asia*, *10*(1), 142–145.

Journal Correspondence

[2] Jamil, S., **Obaidullah, M.**, & Alam, M. (2023). Unusual increase of cesarean section delivery in Bangladesh: Correspondence. *Annals of Medicine and Surgery*, *85*(5), 2242.

[1] **Obaidullah, M.**, Jamil, S., Mohammad Ali, H., & Akhter, A. (2023). Burning up: How heatwaves pose a threat to public health. *IJS Short Reports*, *8*(3), Article e0067.

Fellowships and Awards

2026 **John L. Nau III Graduate Fellowship**, University of Virginia

2024–2025 **Outstanding Graduate Student in Political Science**, University of Southern Mississippi

Research Experience

2022–2023 **Research Assistant**, BRAC James P Grant School of Public Health, Dhaka, Bangladesh (remote)

2021–2022 **Research Assistant**, Centre for Advanced Research, Dhaka, Bangladesh

Teaching Experience

Daffodil International University
Lecturer

Spring 2024 Introduction to Bangladesh Studies (BNS 101); six sections, 300 students.

University of Southern Mississippi
Teaching Assistant

Term	Course	Sections	Students
Fall 2025	Introduction to Law in American Society (PS 380)	1	35
Fall 2025	U.S. Constitutional Law (PS 480)	1	25
Fall 2025	Research Methods (SSGS 400)	1	40
2024–2025	American Government (PS 101)	3	150
2024–2025	Race and Ethnic Politics (PS 306)	2	70
2024–2025	Politics and Protests (PS 453)	1	20

Conference Presentations

2026 Midwest Political Science Association Annual Conference

2025 Midwest Political Science Association Annual Conference

Selected Policy Writing

Obaidullah, M. (2026). Asia's migrant workers need protection from Gulf wars. *The Diplomat*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). The border killing fields separating India and Bangladesh. *Asia Times*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). China quietly eclipsing a weakened Russia in Central Asia. *Asia Times*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). Why the EU–India trade deal could be bad news for Bangladesh. *The Diplomat*.

Obaidullah, M. (2025). CPEC's Afghan push poses a new challenge for India. *East Asia Forum*.

Obaidullah, M. (2025). India's opposition to Bangladesh's defense modernization is a self-defeating strategy. *The Diplomat*.

Editorial and Policy Experience

2025–2026 **Public Affairs and Consular Intern**, Bangladesh High Commission to the Maldives, Malé, Maldives (remote)

2024–2025 **Commissioning Editor**, E-International Relations, United Kingdom (remote)

2021 **Policy Research Intern**, Youth Policy Forum (YPF), Dhaka, Bangladesh

Scholarly Service

Ad hoc reviewer: Geoforum; *Global Change, Peace & Security*; *International Migration*; *International Journal of Water Resources Development*; *Southeast Asia: A Multidisciplinary Journal*.

Methods Training

2024 Data Analytics with R for Data Science, Statistical Research Consultants in Bangladesh, Dhaka, Bangladesh

2021 Qualitative Data Analysis Using NVivo, Centre for Advanced Research, Dhaka, Bangladesh

Software and Languages

Statistical R; SPSS

Qualitative NVivo

Survey Qualtrics

Writing LaTeX; BibTeX; Zotero; Mendeley

Languages Bangla (native); English (fluent); Hindi (conversational); Arabic (basic)

Updated November 2026